MONEY MADE SIMPLE · CHECKLIST + LETTERS + TRACKER

The Credit Report Audit Kit

Read your credit reports like an auditor, find the mistakes that cost you, and dispute them yourself with ready-to-send letters. No credit repair company needed.

~90 minutes | 3 letter templates | Dispute tracker | Freeze in 15 min



Edition 1.0 · US credit reports

Educational content. Not legal or financial advice.

START HERE

What's inside

Your credit reports decide a lot: loan rates, apartment applications, sometimes insurance prices and deposits. Errors are common enough that it's worth checking every year. This kit turns that into a 90-minute job.

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How to use the tracker

Credit-Audit-Tracker.xlsx has four tabs: **Accounts** (each account and what each bureau shows), **Disputes** (when you sent each one and when an answer is due), **Utilization** (how much of your limits you're using, and what to pay to reach a target) and **Freeze Record**. Yellow cells are inputs; white cells calculate. It opens in Excel, Google Sheets and Numbers, and comes with a made-up example.

PLEASE READ

This kit is general education about US consumer credit reports. It is not legal or financial advice. Rules and bureau policies change; check the official sources named in this guide (the CFPB, the FTC and AnnualCreditReport.com) for the current version. You can only dispute information you believe is inaccurate or incomplete. Disputing accurate information to try to get it removed doesn't work and can slow down real disputes. If you're dealing with identity theft, lawsuits or collections you can't manage, consider a non-profit credit counsellor or a consumer lawyer.

NEVER STORE PASSWORDS OR PINS IN THE TRACKER

The Freeze Record tab notes *where* you keep your bureau logins, not the logins themselves. Use a password manager.

STEP 1 · 15 MINUTES

Get all three reports, free

There are three nationwide credit bureaus: Equifax, Experian and TransUnion. Each keeps its own report on you, and they don't always match. Check all three.

THE ONLY OFFICIAL FREE SITE

AnnualCreditReport.com is the site set up under federal law for free reports. You can get a free report from each bureau there, and as of this edition the bureaus offer them every week. Type the address yourself; look-alike sites exist.

1. **Request all three at once** and download each as a PDF. Save them in a folder named with today's date.
2. **Expect identity questions** about past addresses or loans. If you can't get through online, you can request by phone or mail through the same site.
3. **Skip the upsells.** You don't need to buy a score, monitoring or a "credit lock" subscription to get your reports.

What's in a report (and what isn't)

Section	What it shows
Personal information	Names, addresses, date of birth, sometimes employers. Not used to calculate scores, but wrong entries can signal mixed files or identity theft.
Accounts (tradelines)	Every credit card and loan: lender, open date, limit or original amount, balance, status, and a month-by-month payment history.
Collections	Debts sold or assigned to collection agencies.
Public records	Mainly bankruptcies.
Inquiries	"Hard" inquiries from credit applications, and "soft" ones (like pre-approved offers or your own checks) that don't affect scores.

Not in a report: your credit score, income, bank balances, and (usually) rent and utility payments unless a service reports them. Your score is calculated *from* the report, which is why fixing the report matters more than chasing the score.

STEP 2 · 45 MINUTES

The line-by-line audit

Go through one report at a time with a highlighter (or the Accounts tab open). Mark anything that's wrong, missing or that you don't recognise. Don't dispute anything yet.

Personal information

- [ ] Name spellings and variations are yours
- [ ] Every address is one you've lived at
- [ ] Date of birth and SSN digits are right
- [ ] No accounts belonging to a relative with a similar name (Jr./Sr. mix-ups)

Each account

- [ ] You recognise the account and lender
- [ ] It's listed once (not duplicated)
- [ ] Open date and credit limit are right
- [ ] Balance matches your latest statement (roughly; reports lag a month)
- [ ] Status is right: open, closed, "closed by consumer", paid
- [ ] No late payments in months you paid on time
- [ ] Paid-off loans show a $0 balance
- [ ] Debts discharged in bankruptcy show as discharged

Collections

- [ ] You recognise the original debt
- [ ] Amount is right
- [ ] The same debt isn't listed twice (original lender *and* collector both showing a balance)
- [ ] Paid collections show as paid
- [ ] Nothing older than about 7 years from the original delinquency

Inquiries

- [ ] Every hard inquiry is from something you applied for
- [ ] None older than 2 years

Across all three reports

- [ ] An account is missing from one bureau? That's usually not an error: lenders don't have to report to all three
- [ ] The same account shows *different* late payments on different reports? One of them is likely wrong

RED FLAGS FOR IDENTITY THEFT

Accounts you didn't open, inquiries from lenders you never contacted, or addresses you've never lived at. Go straight to page 9 before anything else.

STEP 3

Errors vs. real negatives

The law lets you dispute information that's inaccurate or incomplete. Accurate negative information generally stays for a set time, then falls off on its own. Knowing which is which saves you weeks.

Item	Typical time on report	Can you dispute it?
Late payment you didn't make late	—	**Yes.** Send proof (bank statement or payment confirmation).
Accurate late payment	Up to 7 years	No. You can ask the lender for a goodwill removal (page 8). They don't have to.
Collection that isn't yours or is the wrong amount	—	**Yes.** To the bureau and the collector.
Accurate collection	Up to 7 years from the original delinquency	No. Paying it may still help with lenders, and some newer scoring models ignore paid collections.
Paid medical collection	—	The three bureaus have said they no longer report paid medical collections, or medical collections under $500. If one appears, dispute it.
Hard inquiry you didn't authorise	—	**Yes.** Also check for identity theft.
Hard inquiry you did authorise	Shown 2 years; affects scores less over time	No.
Chapter 7 bankruptcy	Up to 10 years	Only if details are wrong.
Wrong personal info	—	**Yes.** Quick fix, worth doing.

ABOUT "CREDIT REPAIR" COMPANIES

Anything a credit repair company can legally do, you can do yourself for free with this kit. Under federal law (the Credit Repair Organizations Act) they can't charge you before they've done the work, and no one can legally remove accurate, current negative information. Be wary of anyone who promises a specific score, tells you to dispute everything, or suggests a "new credit identity". That last one is illegal.

Prioritise: identity theft first, then wrong late payments and collections, then wrong balances or limits (they affect utilization, page 10), then personal info and old inquiries.

STEP 4 · 20 MINUTES PER DISPUTE

How to dispute, step by step

You can dispute with the credit bureau that shows the error, with the company that reported it (the "furnisher"), or both. Start with the bureau.

1. **Gather proof.** Statements, payment confirmations, letters, a paid-in-full letter, a police or FTC identity theft report. Copies only; never send originals.
2. **Choose online or mail.** Each bureau has an online dispute centre on its own website, which is fastest and lets you upload documents. Mail (certified, return receipt) gives you the strongest paper trail and lets you explain in your own words. Use the letter on page 7.
3. **One item, one clear sentence.** "Account ending 4821 shows a 30-day late payment in March 2026. I paid on time on March 3. Proof attached." Specific beats long.
4. **Log it.** Add the date sent, method and bureau to the Disputes tab. It calculates when an answer is due.
5. **Wait for the result.** Bureaus generally have 30 days to investigate (it can be up to 45 in some cases, for example if you send more information during the investigation). They must send you the results and a free updated report if anything changed.
6. **If it's "verified" and you still think it's wrong:** dispute directly with the furnisher (page 8), send any new evidence to the bureau, ask the bureau to add a short statement to your file, and you can submit a complaint to the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau at consumerfinance.gov/complaint.

Bureau dispute contacts

Get the current dispute address and online link from each bureau's own website (search "*[bureau name] dispute*" and make sure you're on equifax.com, experian.com or transunion.com). Addresses change, so this guide doesn't print them. Note the one you use in the Disputes tab.

> **KEEP A PAPER TRAIL**
>
> Save confirmation numbers, screenshots, certified mail receipts and every letter you get back in the same dated folder as your reports.

TEMPLATE 1

Dispute letter to a credit bureau

Fill in the brackets, delete what doesn't apply, attach copies of your proof and a copy of your ID and proof of address. Send it certified mail with a return receipt.

[Your full name]
[Your address]
[Date of birth] · [Last 4 digits of SSN]

[Date]

[Credit bureau name]
[Dispute address from the bureau's website]

Re: Dispute of inaccurate information, report number [number, if shown]

To whom it may concern,

I am writing to dispute the following information in my credit file. The items I dispute are also circled on the attached copy of my report.

1. [Company name], account ending [last 4 digits]. This account shows [describe exactly what is wrong, e.g. "a 30-day late payment for March 2026"]. This is inaccurate because [reason, e.g. "I made the payment on March 3, 2026, before the due date"]. I am enclosing [describe proof].

2. [Next item, same format.]

I request that these items be corrected [or: deleted], and that you send me written results of your investigation and an updated copy of my credit report.

Enclosures: [list each document: copy of ID, proof of address, statement dated ..., payment confirmation ...]

Sincerely,
[Signature]
[Printed name]

Adapted from the structure of the sample dispute letters published by the Federal Trade Commission and the CFPB, which you can also find on consumer.ftc.gov and consumerfinance.gov.

TEMPLATES 2 AND 3

Letters to the lender

Template 2: dispute to the furnisher

Use the lender's or collector's address for disputes (often on your statement or website). Same rules: specific, with proof, by certified mail.

[Your name] · [Address] · [Account number]

[Date]

[Company name], [Dispute / credit reporting address]

Re: Dispute of information you report to credit bureaus, account ending [last 4]

You are reporting [describe the item, e.g. "a balance of $1,240"] on the account above to [Equifax / Experian / TransUnion]. This is inaccurate because [reason]. Enclosed is [proof]. Please investigate, correct the information you report to every credit bureau you report to, and confirm the correction to me in writing.

Sincerely, [Signature]

Template 3: goodwill request (for an accurate late payment)

This is a polite request, not a dispute. The lender has no obligation to agree, and many won't, but it costs a stamp. It works best when the late payment was a one-off and your account is otherwise in good standing.

[Your name] · [Address] · [Account number]

[Date]

[Company name], [Customer service address]

Re: Goodwill adjustment request, account ending [last 4]

I've been a customer since [year] and I value the account. In [month/year] my payment was late because [one honest sentence, e.g. "I changed banks and my autopay didn't transfer"]. I paid as soon as I noticed and [have paid on time since / have set up autopay].

I understand the late payment was reported accurately. I'm writing to ask whether you would consider a goodwill adjustment to remove it from my credit reports, as it doesn't reflect my usual payment history. Thank you for considering it.

Sincerely, [Signature]

STEP 5 · 15 MINUTES

Freeze your credit, spot identity theft

A credit freeze stops most lenders from seeing your report, which stops most new accounts being opened in your name. It's free, it doesn't affect your score, and you can lift it whenever you apply for credit.

BUREAU 1

Equifax

equifax.com → search "credit freeze"

BUREAU 2

Experian

experian.com → search "freeze"

BUREAU 3

TransUnion

transunion.com → search "credit freeze"

- **Freeze at all three.** A freeze at one doesn't cover the others.
- **It's free by federal law**, both to place and to lift. Decline any paid "lock" product you're offered on the way; you don't need it to freeze.
- **Lifting is quick.** Requests made online or by phone generally have to be processed within an hour. You can lift for a set period while you apply for a card, loan or apartment, then it re-freezes.
- **Keep the login or PIN safe** in a password manager, and note where in the Freeze Record tab.
- **A freeze doesn't stop** your existing lenders using your report, or misuse of accounts you already have. Keep checking statements.

Freeze vs. fraud alert

A **fraud alert** is free and tells lenders to take extra steps to verify it's you. Place it with one bureau and that bureau must tell the other two. A standard alert lasts one year. A freeze is stronger; an alert is easier while you're actively applying for credit.

IF YOU FIND ACCOUNTS THAT AREN'T YOURS

Go to **IdentityTheft.gov** (run by the FTC). It walks you through a recovery plan and creates an Identity Theft Report you can send to bureaus and lenders, which gives your disputes extra weight. Then freeze at all three bureaus and dispute each fraudulent item.

STEP 6

Utilization and your 90-day plan

After payment history, how much of your card limits you're using ("utilization") is one of the biggest factors in most credit scores. It's also the fastest to change, because it's based on the balances that are reported now.

```
utilization = total card balances ÷ total card limits   e.g. $1,200 ÷ $4,000 = 30%
```

- **Lower is generally better.** A common rule of thumb is to stay under 30%, and people with the highest scores are often under 10%. It's looked at both overall and per card.
- **The balance that's reported is usually your statement balance**, not what you owe on the due date. Paying part of the balance *before the statement closes* lowers what gets reported.
- **Closing an old card** removes its limit, which can push utilization up. If it has no annual fee, keeping it open and using it occasionally is often better.
- **Utilization has no long memory** in most scores: once balances drop and are reported, the effect usually follows within a month or two.

The Utilization tab shows your rate per card and overall, and exactly how much to pay down to reach a target you choose.

Your 90-day plan

When	Do this
Day 1	Pull all three reports. Freeze at all three bureaus. Set autopay for at least the minimum on every card and loan (late payments are the most damaging item).
Week 1	Run the audit. Send disputes for the top-priority errors. Log them.
Week 2	Fill in the Utilization tab. Pick a target. Plan payments before each statement date.
Day 30–45	Check dispute results. Re-dispute or go to the furnisher if needed. Send goodwill letters.
Day 90	Pull fresh reports and confirm corrections. Set a reminder to audit again in 6–12 months.

PRINT ME

Audit worksheet

Reports pulled on: _____ Freezes placed: ☐ Equifax ☐ Experian ☐ TransUnion

Account / item	EQ	EX	TU	What looks wrong	Proof I have	Disputed on

Card	Limit	Balance	Used %	Statement closes on
Total				

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WHAT'S NEXT

Clean report. Now lower the balances.

Fixing errors stops your report working against you. Paying down balances is what moves it forward, and it saves you interest every month you do it.

If the Utilization tab showed balances you'd like gone, **The Debt-Free Date Planner** turns them into a dated plan: up to 10 debts, avalanche, snowball or your own order, a payoff month for every debt, and calculators that check whether a balance transfer or consolidation loan would actually save you money.

NEXT STEP

The Debt-Free Date Planner

Guide + spreadsheet. Your debt-free date, the interest you'll save, and call scripts for lower rates.

$17

Credit Audit Kit buyers: code **AUDIT5** for $5 off.

EVERYTHING

The Money Made Simple Toolkit

All five kits, including the 20-Minute Budget and Start Investing With $100 a Month.

$39

Saves $23 against buying them one by one.

Find both at [your store link]. Educational content only, not financial advice.